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CPRE 4940

A Reflective Journey: Navigating Your Cumulative Experience at Iowa State University

Over my time at Iowa State University, I have grown as a student, communicator, leader, engineer, and friend. It has exposed me to many ideas and interests that will shape my future, both personally and professionally.

When I arrived at ISU, I declared my major as Software Engineering. I gained software experience in clubs and classes in high school; I believed it was the career path I should pursue and didn't imagine changing my mind. I added a cybersecurity minor to make my resume more competitive and fill in some of the gaps that were left from high school transfer credits. After taking CPRE 2300 and 2310, I realized that this was the content I was most passionate about, and that my security interest was quickly rising. During the spring semester of my sophomore year, I switched my major to Cybersecurity Engineering. Through courses taken at Iowa State, I found a new passion, and it is shaping my career and life moving forward.

One of the most important opportunities that ISU has provided me with is the ability to work with the content hands-on. I enjoyed those initial cybersecurity classes so much because the labs gave me the opportunity to test and apply our in-class discussions. The course content supported the labs, which allowed me to apply my learning directly. The strategies I learned in those labs will help me to continue to problem-solve in the future. There are several times I found myself facing an issue I had no idea how to fix. Through those "bugs", I have developed strategies to work through the problem, find a solution, and adapt to a new approach. In CPRE 2310, we focus on pen testing and approaches to exploiting devices using real industry tools. Our final project required us to pen test several machines using strategies discussed over the

semester. Many attempts that I made to break into the machine failed and required me to rethink and adapt based on new information. Real experience in my classes helped me to learn how to solve problems through a series of hypotheses, testing, and revision.

Additionally, my cybersecurity ethics course helped me to develop my thoughts, opinions, and feelings about ethical problem-solving and how to deal with situations that may arise in my future career. As a cybersecurity engineer, I will have a lot of responsibility to protect data and ensure ethical practices by the company. We discussed user data protection and privacy rights, which are all major conversations facing consumers today. I valued the in-class discussions that have helped me to understand my thoughts and feelings towards these topics, and the principles I hope to follow as a cybersecurity engineer.

I have learned beyond the classroom through resources provided by the school, club involvement, and internship opportunities. Throughout my time, there have been papers and standards document that professors have provided me to advance my learning. I have found that taking time to read the additional resources can provide additional context to the course content. Even just a few extra minutes have helped me to excel in my courses. I will continue to take this approach in the future for continued growth throughout my career. Beyond school, I have joined several clubs and organizations over my time at ISU. The Cybersecurity and Hacking Club is a weekly club that has been a great way to connect with other people with similar interests. We focused on interesting topics within security, providing me with new topics to explore within cybersecurity. It can be hard to keep up with everything that is changing within security, so having a community of other interested individuals has helped me to stay up to date on changes and advancements.

Club involvement has helped me to build leadership skills as well. I have participated in the Engineering Career Fair as an ambassador, executive team member, and director. Throughout my time, I have been able to build my ability to communicate and organize large groups of people. Volunteering at the career fair has been valuable, as leadership qualities are highly sought after within the industry. Continuing to find opportunities for improving my ability to effectively communicate and take on additional responsibilities will be important in improving and advancing my career. Finally, I have learned through internship experience. As I have mentioned before, hands-on experience is highly valuable. I was an intern during the Summer of 2026 at Principal Financial Group on the Identity and Access Management team as an Information Security intern. My project allowed me to work with another intern using technologies such as AWS that I didn't have experience with before. Throughout my summer, I found that asking questions to real experts in the field was highly valuable. Looking forward to the future, I will continue to ask questions, learn new technologies, and work with others.

Iowa State University has shown me the importance of continuing education and putting the extra effort into developing my skills. In a field such as cybersecurity, always being willing to learn and grow is crucial. I have gathered the skills required for continued education throughout my career. Iowa State has provided me with a new passion that will give me a lifetime of learning.